IASA canvases, explained with AIForge

What each canvas is for, and the same canvas filled in for our own AI developer.

First
how canvases help

Then
14 canvases, one by one

Each time
the AIForge example

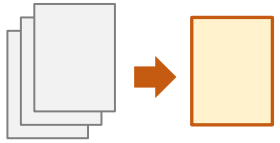
Roles only. No names, no customer detail.

How canvases help

Six reasons to fill a one-page canvas instead of writing a long document

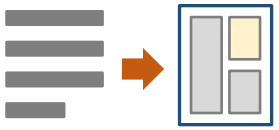
1 One page, not a book

One page gets read. Fifty pages do not.



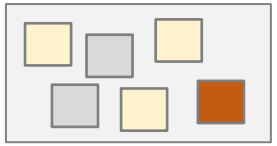
2 A picture beats words

A box you must fill forces a clear answer.



3 Everyone sees one wall

Pin it up. Fill it together with sticky notes.



4 Each canvas feeds the next

The person shapes the journey; the journey shapes the rules.



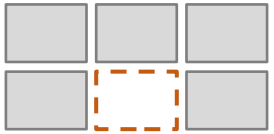
5 Choices can be traced

Rule, choice, number — linked. No arguing again later.



6 Gaps show up early

An empty box is a question nobody has answered.



In short: a canvas is a one-page question sheet. Fill the boxes and anyone can check the thinking.

The canvases at a glance

14 canvases, grouped by the question each one answers

Why? the business	Who? the people	What? the service	How? the design	Where next? the plan
1 Business Model Canvas	2 Persona Card	5 Use Case Card	10 ASR Card	13 OKR Card
	3 Customer Journey Map	6 Context View	11 QATT Card	14 Roadmap Canvas
	4 Power / Interest Grid	7 Service Blueprint	12 Decision Record (ADR)	
		8 Capability Map		
		9 Capability Card		

In short: start with why and who. The design canvases only make sense after those.

Our example: AIForge

One input, one output — and nobody has to watch in between

A ticket

Written in plain words, the way you would ask a colleague

AIForge

A small team of AI agents on our own machines plans, writes, tests and checks the change

A pull request

A tested code change, ready for a person to read and accept

Our machines only

No cloud. No code or data leaves the building.

Seven small agents

Each has one small job and only the context it needs.

A person acts twice

Write the ticket. Read the pull request.

In short: keep this picture in mind — every canvas that follows describes it from a different side.

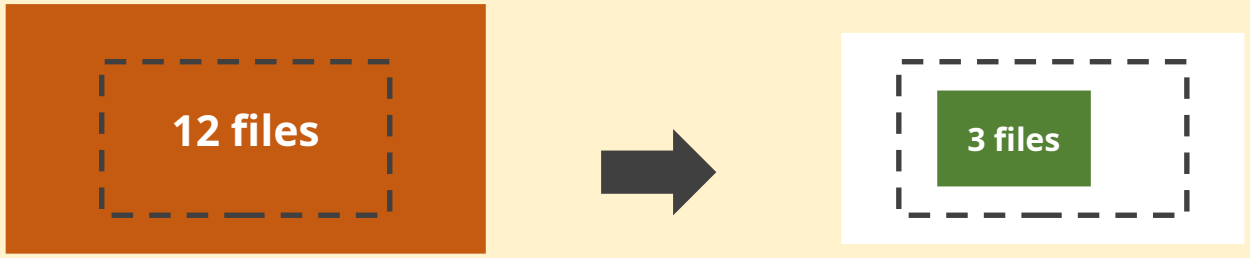
How AIForge works inside

Seven small AI agents, each with one small job, in order

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Enhancer	**Architect**	**Senior dev**	**Developer**	**Tester**	**Reviewer**	**Joiner**
makes the ticket clear	splits the work, writes one plan	sets the shape of the code	writes each part	writes and runs tests	a second AI checks	joins it all, builds until it passes

Why split the work?

A local AI model can hold only 3–5 files in mind at once (the dashed box). One big job does not fit. Small jobs do.



One big job: does not fit **One small job: fits**

In short: one shared plan first, tests before code, and nothing is accepted unless it builds.

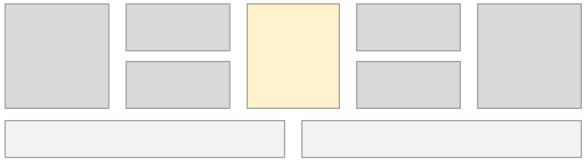
Business Model Canvas

It answers: how does this create value, and for whom?

WHAT IT IS

Nine boxes that show how something gives value, to whom, and at what cost.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

Ticket in, tested pull request out. It costs machines and one person; it gives senior hours back.

WHO HELPS

IT operations
QA and testers

WHAT IT DOES

Plan, write, test, check

WHAT IT NEEDS

Own machines
AI models
Past run notes

WHAT IT GIVES

Ticket in, tested pull request out.

Code never leaves the building.

TRUST

An honest result on every pull request

HOW TO REACH IT

Chat
Ticket tracker

WHO IT SERVES

Delivery engineers
Junior developers
Engineering leads

WHAT IT COSTS

Machines, computing time, and one person to run it

WHAT COMES BACK

Senior hours freed for the hard work; more delivered by the same team

In short: AIForge sells nothing. It gives senior hours back, inside our own walls.

Persona Card

It answers: who exactly are we building for?

WHAT IT IS

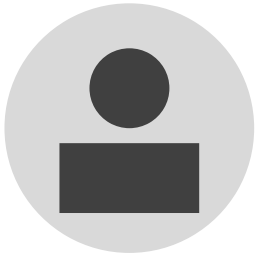
One page about one real kind of user, in their own words.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

The delivery engineer: “Half my week goes on work I already know how to do.”



PRIMARY PERSONA

Delivery engineer

“Half my week goes on work I already know how to do.”

THEIR DAY

- Looks after part of a live system
- Three to six small tickets a week
- Interrupted often; little quiet time

WHAT THEY WANT

- Routine code done for them
- Keep the interesting work
- Never hand code to an outside service

WHAT BLOCKS THEM

- A pull request they do not trust
- A tool that stops half-way and says nothing
- Lots of setup before the tool helps

WHAT EARNS TRUST

- It compiles, or it says it failed
- “I could not do this” in the first line
- A second AI checked the work

In short: it is built for the delivery engineer. If their day does not change, nothing else matters.

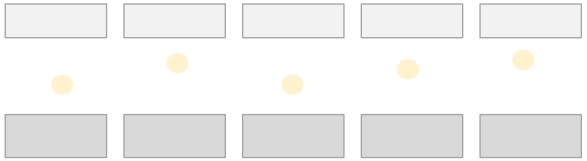
Customer Journey Map

It answers: where does the person wait, and how does it feel?

WHAT IT IS

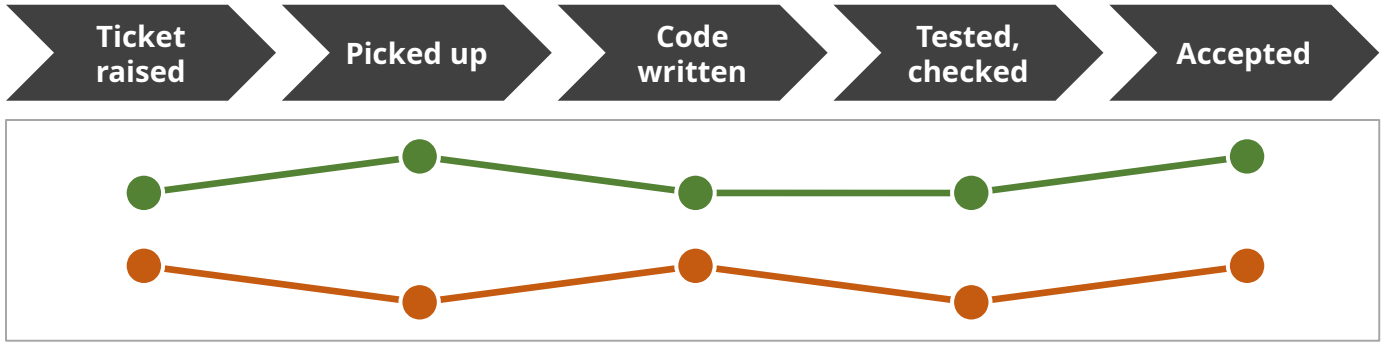
The steps a person goes through, and how each step feels.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

Today a ticket waits days for a senior. With AIForge the work starts at once.



	Ticket raised	Picked up	Code written	Tested, checked	Accepted
Today	sits in the backlog	waits for a senior to be free	done between other work	rushed at the end	days after it was raised
With AIForge	picked up as written	a run starts, nobody waits	agents write it in a copy of the code	tests first, then a second AI checks	pull request ready to read

In short: the cost was never the typing — it was the waiting. AIForge removes the wait.

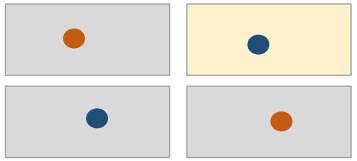
Power / Interest Grid

It answers: who must we win over, and who must own it?

WHAT IT IS

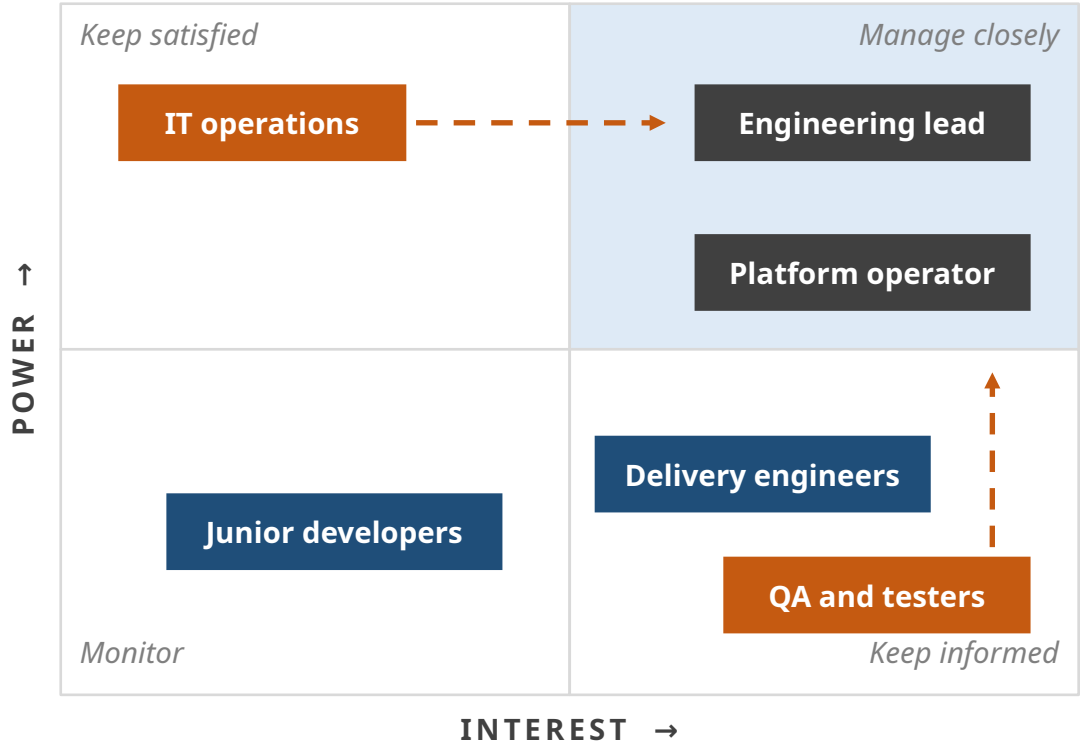
A two-by-two: each group placed by its power and its interest.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

IT and QA must move from watching to owning. The platform needs a second person.



The moves we need

IT operations
watching → owning the AI models

QA and testers
affected → owning the test check

Platform operator
one person → two

In short: the tool works. What is left is people — three jobs still have no owner.

Use Case Card

It answers: who starts it, what happens, and what comes out?

WHAT IT IS

One job the system does: who starts it, the steps, the result.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

An engineer files a ticket. Seven steps later a pull request is ready to read.

ACTOR AND TRIGGER

Delivery engineer
files a ticket in the tracker

Runs several times a week

MUST ALREADY BE TRUE

- The ticket names a real project
- The AI models are ready
- The code builds before we start

MAIN FLOW

1. Someone files a ticket in plain words
2. The ticket is rewritten so it is clear
3. The work is split; one shared plan is written
4. Each part is built in its own copy of the code
5. Tests are written, then run against the build
6. A second AI checks the change
7. A pull request opens with an honest result

OUTCOME

A pull request
a person reviews

Or a first line
saying it could not

Either way
a record of the run

In short: the senior spends minutes reading instead of hours writing.

Context View

It answers: what is inside the system, and what does it touch?

WHAT IT IS

The system as one box, with what goes in and what comes out.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

Tickets and code go in. A pull request comes out. All of it stays on our own machines.

GOES IN

- Tickets from the tracker
- The code and its history
- Past runs and lessons

our own machines

AIForge
Plans the work
Writes and tests code
Checks and joins it

COMES OUT

- A pull request
- A record of the run
- New lessons stored

WHAT WE ASSUME

- The AI models are set up right
- The models stay ready, or runs stop half-way
- The ticket names a real project

WHAT TO BEWARE OF

- About 3–5 files is today's limit
- Some coding languages are too hard for small models
- Shared machines limit how many tickets run at once

In short: write the unknowns down, not just the boxes — the edges are where runs fail.

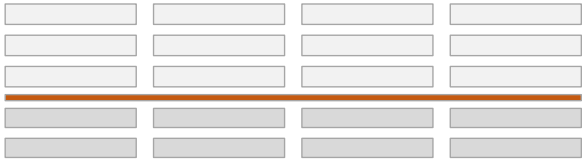
Service Blueprint

It answers: what does the person see, and what runs behind it?

WHAT IT IS

The service in layers: what people see on top, the machinery below.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

The person files a ticket and reads the result. The agents do the rest, out of sight.

	1. Ask	2. Work	3. Check	4. Hand back
The person sees	the ticket they wrote	a run in progress	test output	a pull request and a result
The person does	files it, in plain words	nothing — goes elsewhere	nothing	reads, comments, accepts
The system shows	ticket is picked up	a copy of the code opens	build check runs	pull request opens
line of visibility — below this, nobody is watching				
Agents (hidden)	make the ticket clear	plan, then write	test, check, join up	write the result
Platform (hidden)	ticket store	AI models on our machines	build tools, test runners	run history, lessons kept

In short: above the line there are two moments: file it, read it. The design work is all below.

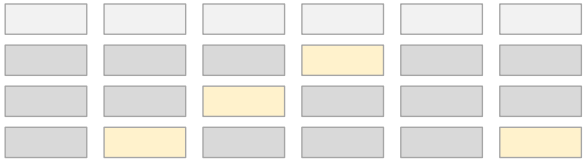
Business Capability Map

It answers: what must the business be good at — and who does it today?

WHAT IT IS

A grid of everything the business must be able to do.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

AIForge does 11 of the 18 jobs today and 3 more in part. The rest is still all people.

Understand the ask	Design the change	Build the change	Prove quality	Release and run	Learn and improve
Capture a ticket	Read the codebase	Write the code	Write tests	Open a pull request	Keep lessons
Clarify what is wanted	Split the work	Join files together	Run the build	Accept the change	Share across the team
Prioritise	Agree how parts connect	Keep to standards	Second check	Run the platform	Measure use

AIForge does this today · Partly — being built · Still all people

In short: 11 of 18 done by AIForge today, 3 partly. The rest still needs an owner.

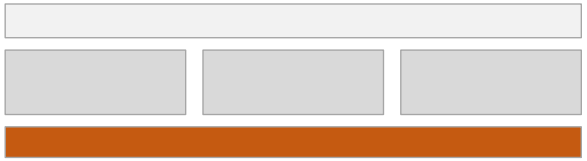
Capability Card

It answers: what does one ability need — people, process, tools?

WHAT IT IS

One ability taken apart: people, process, tools, and how grown-up it is.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

“Build the change” is rated Good. The gap: 3–5 files today, 8–10 wanted.

BUILD THE CHANGE
Turn an agreed plan into code that builds and fits the project.

HOW MATURE

Growing	**Good**	Strong

1 People

- One person runs the platform today
- Delivery engineer reviews the output
- Nobody owns the AI models yet

2 Process

- Plan written before any code
- Each part built in its own copy
- Only code that builds is accepted

3 Tools

- AI models on our own machines
- Code map and memory of past runs
- Build and test tools already in use

GAP TO TARGET

Limit is 3–5 files; we want 8–10

Memory not yet shared across the team

No second person trained yet

In short: to improve: bigger AI models, shared memory, and a named owner for the platform.

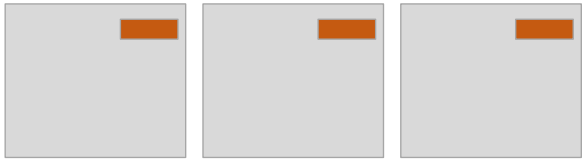
ASR Card

It answers: which few rules shape the whole design?

WHAT IT IS

ASR = a must-have rule. Break it and the whole design fails.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

Three rules: do the job alone, make the files fit together, stay on our machines.

THE WHOLE AIFORGE DESIGN RESTS ON THREE RULES

1 HIGH

Do the job on its own

Ticket in, pull request out. Nobody in the middle.

RISK Bad automatic changes destroy trust fast.

PROOF First full run: ticket to pull request with no help.

2 HIGH

Make the files fit together

Change five files and they still build as one.

RISK Big tickets look done but do not build.

PROOF 0 → 53 working linked lines with a shared plan.

3 MEDIUM-HIGH

Stay on our machines

Machines we own. No cloud. Works offline.

COST Our own AI models are weaker than cloud ones.

PROOF Zero runs have sent data outside.

In short: three rules hold up the whole design. Break any one and the tool is not worth using.

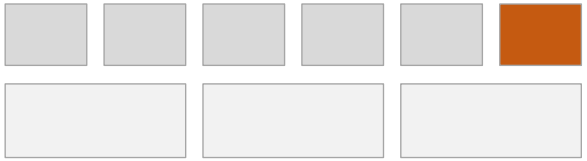
QATT Card

It answers: how do we turn “it must be good” into a number?

WHAT IT IS

A quality written as a test: who does what, and what we measure.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

A five-file ticket must come out as one change that builds. Measured: 0 → 53 working lines.

SCENARIO A multi-file ticket comes out as one working change

WHO	DOES WHAT	WHERE	TO WHAT	RESULT	MEASURE
A delivery engineer	files a ticket that touches five files	a normal run on our own machines	the AIForge agents	one merged change that builds	**0 → 53 working linked lines**

MORE SCENARIOS

Nothing leaves our network

Check: A check fails the build if it would call out

Running today, small batch

We know the size limit

Check: Count files one ticket handles cleanly

3–5 files now

Team memory does not grow too big

Check: Count duplicate notes each week

Merge step designed

In short: splitting the work beat waiting for a bigger model — and we have the number to show it.

Decision Record (ADR)

It answers: what did we decide, what else did we consider, and why?

WHAT IT IS

A short note of one choice: what we picked, what we dropped, and why.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

We picked many small agents. We dropped the ready-made tool, one big model, and cloud AI.

THE SITUATION

Our AI models hold about 3–5 files at once. A many-file ticket must still build as one piece, and no code may leave.

REJECTED

Ready-made agent

Broke on our model server; cannot build Java.

REJECTED

One big model

0 working lines on a many-file ticket.

REJECTED

Cloud AI

Works — and sends our code outside. Not allowed.

CHOSEN

Many small agents

0 → 53 working lines. Always builds first.

DECISION — WE WILL…

finish each ticket with a line of small agents, each with one small job. Simple tickets skip the line.

WHAT FOLLOWS

\+ each role is checked on its own; a bad part fails alone
– more AI calls, more waiting, more moving parts

CAN WE UNDO IT?

easy to undo — permanent

Belief we tested: “more agents must be better”
Owner: project lead

In short: we did not pick it because we liked it — it is the one our tests kept passing.

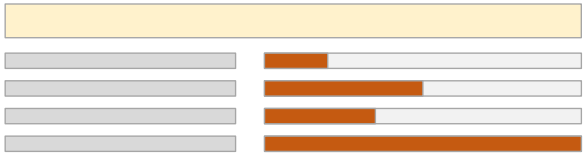
OKR Card

It answers: what does good look like, in numbers we can check?

WHAT IT IS

OKR = one goal, and a few numbers that show progress.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

Goal: small work is done this way. Target: 3 in 4 tickets accepted. Not measured yet.

GOAL **Make AIForge the normal way small work gets done**

WHAT WE MEASURE	PROGRESS TO TARGET	TODAY	TARGET
Tickets that end in an accepted pull request		Not measured	3 in 4
Files one ticket can change cleanly		3 to 5	8 to 10
Tickets filed by people other than the leads		Almost none	Half
People who can run and fix the platform		1	2
Runs where data left our network		Zero	Zero

In short: the tool works; now we must measure how often it succeeds. The first row is the problem.

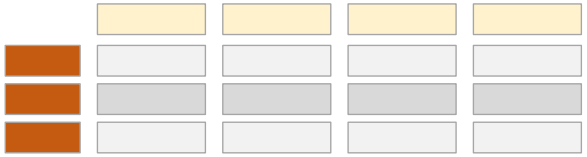
Roadmap Canvas

It answers: what happens when — for product, platform and people?

WHAT IT IS

The plan over time: product, platform and people together.

THE BLANK CANVAS



IN AIFORGE

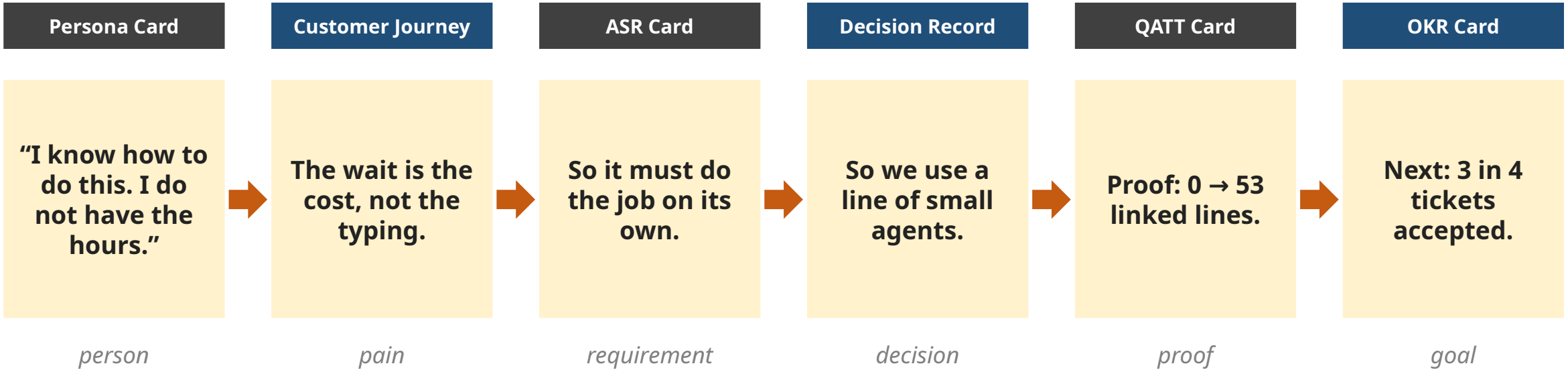
From an honest result on every pull request now, to open for every team by the end of the year.

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
Product	Honest result on every pull request	Team memory sharing live	Bigger tickets, more files	Open to every team
Platform	Bigger machines planned	Bigger AI models tested	IT runs the AI models	Machine needs planned ahead
People	Second person named	QA owns the test check	Juniors start using it	Use measured every month

In short: one rule for the whole year: nothing on this plan moves work off our own machines.

How the canvases connect

One thread through six canvases — each claim has a canvas behind it



Why this matters: change one note and you know which others to revisit. That is the link a long document hides.

In short: the canvases are not fourteen documents. They are one argument on fourteen pages.

What to take away

Four steps to use the canvases on your own work

1 Start with the person

not with the technology

2 One page each

if it does not fit, it is not clear yet

3 Fill in facts

and leave the gaps where all can see

4 Follow the links

pin them side by side

What AIForge taught us

The limit was the design, not the model.

One page per canvas made the thinking easy to check.

A tool one person can run is not yet a tool the company owns.

In short: every claim here has a canvas behind it.